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Life as a Research Assistant Professor at TTIC

As a current RAP at TTIC, I can share that this is a GREAT opportunity for early-career researchers. The position offers three years of guaranteed funding with complete research independence. You get to be your own boss while having the flexibility to collaborate with top students and researchers at TTIC, UChicago, and beyond.

Research Freedom & Productivity

In just 14 months, I've published several new projects at major conferences (CVPR 2024, ECCV 2024, NeurIPS 2024 (2x), and WACV 2025), co-led a multi-university grant proposal with seven senior faculty members (five from TTIC), and co-organized a CVPR 2024 workshop on "Retrospective Vision" and ECCV 2024 workshop on "Knowledge in Generative Models"

Teaching & Mentorship

While there are no teaching requirements, I chose to develop a new computer vision course, "Past Meets Present: A Tale of Two Visions". Teaching this course is one of the best experiences of my stay at TTIC. From preparing course materials to doing practice presentations with students to their final presentation. It was a great exposure and an amazing experience.

RAPs can work with students from TTIC, UChicago, and beyond, and serve on their thesis committees (I have been on two student committees so far). You not only get great mentorship support but you also get opportunities to mentor junior students and researchers. Mentoring students has been particularly rewarding - it's truly an art. I've learned invaluable lessons co-supervising projects with faculty members, observing how they handle projects and how they deal with setbacks, motivate students, and bring out their best potential. This mentorship experience has been as enriching for me as it has been for the students.

Collaborative Environment

The position allows broad collaboration - I've worked with researchers not just from TTIC and UChicago but also from UW, AI2, UIUC, ULaval, and many more ongoing projects with several other universities. The institute provides excellent computing infrastructure and administrative support. My brother during a recent visit, a staff software engineer at Uber, compared TTIC's environment to a startup, though it's more academically focused.

Summary

The RAP position combines the best aspects of postdoc and faculty roles - research freedom without teaching obligations (though you can teach if interested). You can serve as PI on grants, co-advise students, and build your research profile. You can jumpstart your academic or industry research career while hanging out with some of the cool folks doing excellent research I have seen.